steady policy learning about the Afghan Taliban and the myriad interests and ideas the insurgent movement embodied.

This policy learning allowed the conciliators to chart a nuanced policy approach until early 2016 allowing India to secure its interests in Afghanistan, ensuring a balance between Afghanistan and Pakistan, and preventing New Delhi from getting isolated in Afghanistan as it had been after the Soviet withdrawal. Following these sources driving India's foreign policy is crucial to understand which way India's Afghanistan policy will evolve in future. Guided by an enduring vision for the region that requires a stable balance of power across the Durand Line, India will react strongly to any event or process that allows excessive strategic weight to Pakistan in Afghan affairs. However, depending on international and regional geopolitical equations, if there were a balance between Afghanistan and Pakistan, then the conciliators would remain influential. Thus, Pakistan's attempts to push India out of Afghanistan will only increase New Delhi's political will to deepen its footprint in that country. If India can be an enemy across the Hindu Kush, it can also be a friend who understands Pakistan's territorial insecurities, and has little interest in exacerbating them. This is not to say that talking about Afghanistan is a sufficient condition for sustaining an India-Pakistan dialogue, for India-Pakistan talks are highly accident-prone. But discussing the situation in Afghanistan surely is a necessary condition that will impart credibility to such India-Pakistan talks.